

Research Proposal: An Investigation into the Factors Contributing to High Achievement (Band 7+) in the IELTS Academic Test among Recent Test-Takers in Bangladesh

Prepared for: Teachers of Schools and IELTS Preparation Centers

Prepared by: Dr. ABM Asia Kibria, Research and Language Trainer

Date: October 24, 2025

1.0 Introduction and Rationale

The International English Language Testing System (IELTS) serves as a critical gatekeeper for individuals seeking higher education and professional opportunities in English-speaking environments. Achieving a high score, particularly a Band 7 or above in all four modules, places a candidate in the upper echelon of global test-takers and is often a prerequisite for admission to top-tier universities.¹ This achievement signifies a "Good User" with an "operational command of the language," capable of handling complex language and detailed reasoning.³

While the linguistic and cognitive skills required for a high score are well-documented, a comprehensive understanding of *how* students achieve this level of proficiency remains a key area of interest for educators and trainers. This is particularly relevant in a dynamic educational landscape like Bangladesh, where a significant number of students aspire to study abroad. Understanding the specific strategies, psychological attributes, and learning environments of successful candidates can provide invaluable insights for pedagogical improvement.

This research aims to conduct a qualitative case study of students in Bangladesh who have recently achieved a score of Band 7 or higher in all four modules of the IELTS Academic test. The study will move beyond a simple analysis of test scores to create a holistic profile of the high achiever, examining the interplay between their linguistic competencies, learning processes, psychological profiles, and educational contexts. The findings are intended to provide actionable insights for language trainers, educational institutions, and aspiring test-takers.

2.0 Summary of Existing Research

A review of the current literature reveals a multi-faceted model of the high-achieving IELTS candidate, built upon four integrated domains:

- **Linguistic and Strategic Competencies:** High scorers possess not only a large vocabulary and a strong command of complex grammar but also the strategic competence to adapt their skills to the specific demands of each test module.⁴ They are proficient and strategic test-takers who understand how to demonstrate their abilities within the test's constraints.
- **Learning Strategies and Processes:** The journey to a high score is characterized by the active application of specific learning strategies. Successful candidates engage in systematic resource utilization, seek personalized feedback, conduct intensive and targeted practice, and immerse themselves in the English language.⁷ They are active, self-directed learners who consciously manage their preparation.
- **Psychological Profile:** Non-linguistic factors are critical. High achievers are typically driven by strong, goal-oriented motivation and exhibit high levels of self-regulated learning (SRL)—the ability to plan, monitor, and reflect on their own learning process.⁹ Personality traits such as conscientiousness are also strong predictors of success.¹²
- **Contextual Factors:** A student's background and learning environment, including prior educational experiences and access to quality instruction, provide the context for their achievement.² The high-stakes nature of the test also creates a powerful "washback effect" that influences teaching and learning practices.¹⁴

3.0 Research Questions

This case study seeks to build upon the existing literature by exploring the lived experiences of recent high achievers in Bangladesh. The primary research questions are:

1. **Strategy and Process:** How do high achievers in Bangladesh balance the development of general English proficiency with test-specific strategies? What specific resources (e.g., books, tutors, online platforms) and feedback mechanisms do they identify as most critical to their success?
2. **Psychology and Mindset:** How do high achievers describe the relationship between their motivation, their study habits, and their ability to perform under pressure? What specific goal-setting and self-monitoring techniques do they employ to sustain their effort?
3. **Perception and Transition:** To what extent do high achievers perceive the skills tested in IELTS as being aligned with the skills needed for their future academic work? What challenges do they anticipate in transitioning from a test-preparation to a university

environment?

4.0 Proposed Methodology

This study will employ a qualitative case study approach to gain an in-depth understanding of the participants' experiences.¹⁶

- **Participants:** The target participants are students in Bangladesh who have scored Band 7 or higher in all four modules of the IELTS Academic test within the last six months.
- **Data Collection:** Data will be collected through two primary instruments:
 1. **Semi-Structured Interviews with Students:** In-depth interviews will be conducted to explore the research questions, focusing on participants' learning journeys, strategies, motivations, and perceptions.
 2. **Questionnaires for Educators:** A questionnaire will be distributed to principals and teachers at prominent schools and IELTS preparation centers in Bangladesh to gather their expert perspectives on the characteristics and habits of high-achieving students.
- **Data Analysis:** Interview transcripts and questionnaire responses will be analyzed using thematic analysis to identify recurring patterns, themes, and insights related to the research questions.

5.0 Data Collection Instrument: Questionnaire for Educators

The following questionnaire is designed to be completed by principals, academic coordinators, and senior IELTS trainers. Your expert insights are invaluable to this research.

Questionnaire: Educator Perspectives on High-Achieving IELTS Students (Band 7+)

Part A: Institutional and Respondent Information

1. **Name of Institution:**

[illegible]

2. Your Role/Title:

[illegible]

3. Years of Experience in IELTS Training/Education:

Part B: Observations of High-Achieving Students

4. In your experience, what is the typical educational background of students who achieve a Band 7 or higher in all modules? (e.g., English medium school, specific curriculum, prior language training, etc.)

5. Please rate the importance of the following factors for achieving a Band 7+ score.
(1 = Not Important, 5 = Very Important)

Factor	1	2	3	4	5
Prior English medium education	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Strong intrinsic motivation (personal drive)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Parental support and encouragement	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
High-quality teaching/coaching	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Access to specific prep materials (books/apps)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Regular practice with mock tests	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

6. What are the most common psychological attributes you observe in your highest-scoring students? (e.g., highly organized, resilient to stress, confident, self-disciplined, etc.)

Part C: Pedagogical Approaches and Resources

7. Which teaching methodologies does your institution find most effective for preparing students for IELTS? (e.g., Task-Based Learning, Communicative Language Teaching, traditional grammar-translation, etc.)

8. In your opinion, what is the right balance between teaching general English proficiency and teaching specific test-taking strategies?

9. Which specific resources (e.g., textbooks, online platforms, mock test series) do you recommend most often to your students? Why?

10. From your perspective, what is the single biggest challenge for students in Bangladesh aiming for a Band 7+ score, and what is the most effective way to overcome it?

Thank you for your time and contribution to this research.

6.0 Significance of the Study

The findings from this study are expected to have significant pedagogical implications. For language trainers and institutions in Bangladesh, this research will provide an evidence-based profile of successful learners, enabling the refinement of curricula, teaching strategies, and support systems. By understanding the specific methods and mindsets that lead to success, educators can better guide their students. For current and future IELTS candidates, the published case studies will offer a practical, relatable roadmap, demystifying the path to a high score and providing concrete, proven strategies for success.

Works cited

1. News and Insights - IELTS continues to lead, support, and... - IELTS, accessed on October 24, 2025,
<https://ielts.org/news-and-insights/ielts-trusted-by-millions-in-2023>
2. IELTS Test Taker Performance 2021 | PDF | International English ..., accessed on October 24, 2025,
<https://www.scribd.com/document/663117779/IELTS-Test-Taker-Performance-2021>
3. Understanding your score - IELTS, accessed on October 24, 2025,
<https://ielts.org/take-a-test/your-results/ielts-scoring-in-detail>
4. What Factors Most Impact on Chinese Students' Performance in the ..., accessed

on October 24, 2025,

<https://www.scirp.org/journal/paperinformation?paperid=114249>

5. (PDF) Building knowledge about language for teaching IELTS writing tasks: A genre-based approach - ResearchGate, accessed on October 24, 2025, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/371360738_Building_knowledge_about_language_for_teaching_IELTS_writing_tasks_A_genre-based_approach
6. An examination of IELTS candidates' performances at different band ..., accessed on October 24, 2025, <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/2331186X.2020.1770936>
7. Language Learning Strategies Applied By Ielts Overall Band Score-7 Achievers - Journal of Positive School Psychology, accessed on October 24, 2025, <https://www.journalppw.com/index.php/jpsp/article/download/2984/1944/3407>
8. Successful case studies | IELTS-Blog, accessed on October 24, 2025, <https://www.ielts-blog.com/category/successful-case-studies/>
9. Examining the relationship between IELTS preparation and English language proficiency skills of international students - ResearchGate, accessed on October 24, 2025, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/393536367_Examining_the_relationship_between_IELTS_preparation_and_English_language_proficiency_skills_of_international_students
10. Academic Motivation and Self-Regulated Learning in Predicting ..., accessed on October 24, 2025, <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/EJ1060062.pdf>
11. Conscious Self-regulation, Motivational Factors, and Personality Traits as Predictors of Students' Academic Performance: A Linear Empirical Model - PMC - PubMed Central, accessed on October 24, 2025, <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9903235/>
12. The big five factors as differential predictors of self-regulation, achievement emotions, coping and health behavior in undergraduate students, accessed on October 24, 2025, <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC11092092/>
13. (PDF) Relationship Between Learner Background and Pronunciation Gain on IELTS, accessed on October 24, 2025, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/363661773_RELATIONSHIP_BETWEEN_LEARNER_BACKGROUND_AND_PRONUNCIATION_GAIN_ON_IELTS
14. A CRITICAL REVIEW OF THE IELTS IMPACT ON ... - Neliti, accessed on October 24, 2025, <https://media.neliti.com/media/publications/336825-a-critical-review-of-the-ielts-impact-on-c50dde5d.pdf>
15. Full article: Linguistic predictors of academic achievement amongst international students and home students in higher education: introduction - Taylor & Francis Online, accessed on October 24, 2025, <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/13670050.2021.1909452>
16. International English Language Testing System - Wikipedia, accessed on October 24, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/International_English_Language_Testing_System
17. How to Get IELTS Band 7: Tips, Strategies, and Preparation Guide, accessed on

October 24, 2025,

<https://www.shiksha.com/studyabroad/how-to-get-ielts-band-7-tips-strategies-and-preparation-guide-articlepage-179009>